AN ORIGINAL COUNTRY-HOUSE MYSTERY

THE LAST BELL OF ASHCOMBE HOUSE

CLUES & EVIDENCE

12 numbered exhibits. Keep E09 covered until the dispatch-box combination has been checked.



1-6 INVESTIGATORS | 90-120 MINUTES | AGES 14+

An autumn storm. Six suspects. One unfinished announcement.

E01 / OPEN FROM THE START

The library scene

Scene record: Library, Ashcombe House. Discovery at 9:32 p.m. Edmund lies beside the writing desk. No sign of a forced window. Both ordinary doors are unlocked. The service door leads to the pantry passage.

Objects observed: Swallow-handled brass bell on the carpet; crescent chip in its base; dark transfer mark along the chipped edge. The bell is a possible weapon, not a scientifically confirmed one. Do not infer a precise death time from the mark.

Desk: Blue folio, broken seal; one sheet has been torn away leaving a narrow attached margin. Locked three-wheel dispatch box. Unsent envelope beneath the blotter. Nothing has been tidied or removed by the investigators.

Hand: Pale violet cloth fragment, including double stitching and part of a triangular repair, preserved in Edmund's left hand until the constable attends.

Medical observation: Felix reports death and a head injury consistent with a heavy blow. He cannot establish the exact minute. For game purposes, the bell and thud at 9:14 are the event the other evidence must explain.



E02 / OPEN FROM THE START

The evening record

Time	Recorded event	Source / limit
9:05	Gallery photograph; cuff intact	Investigator + plate G-17
9:08	Bell placed on library desk	Martha; investigator sees delivery
9:09	Felix connected to operator	Call pad; not a continuous alibi
9:10	Celia takes cupboard key	Arthur witnesses key entry
9:12-9:18	Nora and Martha upstairs	Martha's corrected account
9:13 / 9:16	Felix in telephone alcove	Gideon; interval unwatched
9:14	Bell, thud, then service door	Investigator + Arthur; Gideon in gallery
About 9:17	Arthur reaches kitchen	Cook's recollection
9:20	Celia at archive desk; cuff torn	Investigator sees her once
9:22	Key returned	Martha witnesses return
9:32	Edmund discovered	Martha opens library
10:10	Fragment comparison recorded	Constable; after narrative events

E03 / OPEN FROM THE START

The cupboard key book

Pantry key register, 17 October: Borrower: Celia Ward. Key: library document cupboard. Taken: 9:10 p.m. Returned: 9:22 p.m. Both entries are in Celia's handwriting.

Arthur witnessed the borrowing. Martha witnessed the return. Nobody watched the book or the key continuously between those times.

The key opens the cupboard containing the inventory papers. It does not open either library door; those doors were unlocked. Possessing the key does not, by itself, prove how long anyone remained in the room.

Celia's statement: "I took in the inventory folio, left Mr Ashcombe alive in less than a minute, and returned directly to the archive. I stayed there until twenty past. The cuff tore on a drawer that afternoon."

Investigator note: Celia was seen at the archive desk at 9:20. That observation does not account for every preceding minute.

Borrower	Key out	Key back
C. Ward	9:10 p.m.	9:22 p.m.

E04 / OPEN FROM THE START

Four witness extracts

The investigator: "The bell rang at 9:14. A heavy noise followed. Gideon stood beside the map-room doorway and said someone had dropped something. At 9:20 I saw Celia at her archive desk. Her right cuff had a jagged gap beside the old repair."

Arthur Bell: "I heard one bell note and then the service door close. I was at the bend in the passage, carrying a bucket. I did not see who used the door. I reached the kitchen about 9:17."

Martha Reed: "Nora was with me upstairs from 9:12 until 9:18. She held the lamp while I inspected the leak. I put the bell on Edmund's desk at 9:08. I saw Celia return the key at 9:22."

Gideon Pike: "Felix was at the telephone when I passed at 9:13, and still there when I looked along the hall at 9:16. I did not watch the alcove between those times."

Reliability note: Martha first omitted the upstairs trip to spare Nora embarrassment. The correction is recorded openly. No witness reports an unidentified stranger, an altered clock or a locked-room mechanism.

E05 / OPEN FROM THE START

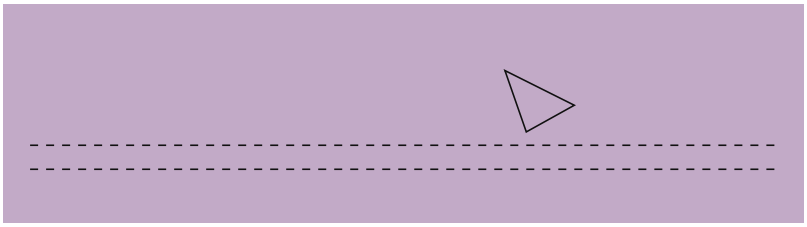
Plate G-17: the intact cuff

Contemporaneous exposure: Gallery, 9:05 p.m. The investigator read the clock aloud immediately before Arthur released the shutter. The single exposed plate was labelled G-17 and developed with the investigator present.

Enlargement observation: Celia's right pale violet cuff is complete. Two parallel stitch lines cross the lower edge. A triangular repair sits near the seam. No gap is present beside it.

Comparison observation: At 9:20 the same cuff has a triangular section missing beside the repair. The afternoon-tear explanation is inconsistent with the earlier intact state.

Limits: The plate alone narrows the damage to 9:05-9:20. It does not show a killing. Use E08 to examine the physical connection. The diagram below is the authoritative game enlargement; the suspect portrait is not evidence.



Schematic textile record - not a photographic reconstruction

E06 / OPEN FROM THE START

Two versions of a payment

Pike & Co. sale statement, 3 October 1934: Original astronomical drawing and original river survey sold for a combined 480 pounds. Seller represented by Celia Ward under a letter of authority bearing Edmund Ashcombe's typed name.

Covering letter to Gideon: "Please remit to the restoration fund account named in the attached instruction. E. Ashcombe prefers all conservation matters to pass through this office." Signed C. Ward.

Carbon remittance advice: Payee: C. Ward, private commission account. Amount: 480 pounds. Reference: two original drawings, Ashcombe collection. This matches the sale statement; it does not describe an estate restoration account.

Inventory discrepancy: Both works remain listed as originals present in the house. Display frames now contain reproductions. Edmund pencilled beside the astronomical entry: "If the original is in York, why has London already sold it?"

Typewriter: The authority letter and provenance notes share a raised right leg on capital R, matching the archive machine. The machine is accessible to others. This is supporting context, not proof of its operator.

E07 / OPEN FROM THE START

The conservation reply

York Drawing Conservation Workshop
4 September 1934
To Miss C. Ward, Ashcombe House

"Thank you for your enquiry. Regrettably we cannot accept the astronomical drawing this season. No object has been delivered to us in connection with your enquiry. Please do not arrange dispatch without a fresh booking."

Collection check: The reply remains in the archive correspondence tray. There is no later booking or dispatch receipt in the case materials. The sale record in E06 independently locates the original outside the collection.

Celia's explanation at 8:50 p.m., 17 October: "The original is in York for conservation. The framed photograph is only temporary."

Question: Which documents contradict that explanation, and what is the difference between proving a false account of a drawing and proving responsibility for the death?

E08 / OPEN AFTER READING THE STORY

The fragment comparison

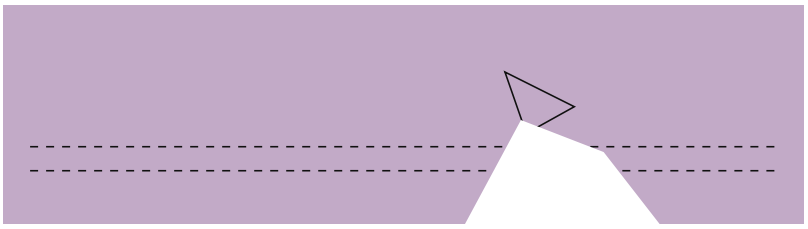
Constable's comparison note, 10:10 p.m.: The cloth removed from Edmund's hand was placed beside the missing section of Celia Ward's right cuff. The irregular edges join at three corners; both stitch lines continue across the join. One leg of the old triangular repair continues from cuff onto fragment.

The comparison is a direct physical fit under a magnifying glass. No chemical test, fibre database or modern DNA analysis is implied. Within this fictional case, accept the recorded fit as reliable.

Timing: E05 places the cuff intact at 9:05. The investigator saw the gap at 9:20. Celia admits a library visit beginning at 9:10 and has no independently observed whereabouts until 9:20.

Alternative claim: Celia says the damage happened in the afternoon. The image observation in E05 contradicts that claim. No earlier confrontation between her and Edmund within the 9:05-9:20 interval is reported apart from the private library meeting.

Reasoning limit: A cloth fit establishes contact and a false explanation. Combine it with the meeting, sound, route and financial records before making the accusation.



Schematic textile record - not a photographic reconstruction

E09 / SEALED: READ ONLY AFTER CODE CHECK

Inside the dispatch box

Carbon audit, signed Edmund Ashcombe, 17 October: "The original astronomical drawing and river survey have been disposed of without my authority. I have compared Pike's statement with the bank advice. Four hundred and eighty pounds went to C. Ward's private commission account. I have never authorized that account to receive estate proceeds."

"The authority supplied to Pike bears my typed name; I did not issue it. Copies have been left in the frames and counted in the inventory as originals. These entries must be corrected before the trust is signed."

Private appointment note: "C. Ward: bring the blue folio to the library after collecting the key at 9:10. We shall discuss the false authority and the missing proceeds privately, before my announcement at 9:30."

Duplicate safeguard: The audit is the carbon counterpart of the sheet torn from the blue folio. The wording at the surviving margin matches. Removing the visible original did not remove this copy.

Do now: Complete the timeline, compare alternatives and write your accusation. This packet proves the intended confrontation and the financial motive. It is not a confession and does not replace the physical evidence.

END OF SEALED EXHIBIT

If you opened this page early, stop here until P1-P3 have been completed. Continue without a penalty; simply record that the reveal was early.

E10 / OPEN FROM THE START

The trust and the creditor

Announcement draft, Edmund's desk: Ashcombe House and the remaining collection will pass into a charitable study trust. Resident staff employment will continue. Nora is to receive a private allowance; she will not be able to sell the collection.

Final handwritten line: "Before signature, the inventory must be corrected and the unauthorized transfers reported." The word "before" is underlined.

Creditor letter, Nora's bag: A repayment of 120 pounds is overdue. Nora admits using the loan to support a theatre company. She had asked Edmund for help and feared the new arrangements would leave her without support.

Martha's information: Edmund had told her that jobs would be protected. She omitted Nora's tears from her first account but later confirmed the upstairs interval.

Investigation prompt: Separate what Edmund actually planned from what each person feared. This evidence explains motive and misunderstanding; it does not move Nora out of Martha's sight at 9:14.

E11 / OPEN FROM THE START

Edmund's three little tasks

Slip beside the dispatch box: "The house, the order, the hour. Three answers, one lock. Read them in that order. Use the booklet and my corrected appointment."

Visitor booklet verse:
Frost silvers the silent lawn.
Oak leaves gather beside the stair.
Under the eaves the swallows sleep.
Rain keeps the evening waiting.

Booklet margin: "Beginnings spell the first number. The second number sits on the second label after the labels are put in order."

Archive labels: A carries 6; B carries 8; C carries 2; D carries 1. B stands immediately before D. C stands last. A stands after D. Use every label once.

Corrected appointment, 16 October: "Telephone conference with solicitor: seven in the evening, replacing nine. Take only the corrected hour as the third digit. This is yesterday's conference, not tonight's announcement."

All the needed information is reproduced on P1-P3. Do not use the date, the victim's age or any real-world historical fact as an extra key.

E12 / OPEN FROM THE START

An ordinary service passage

Route record: The library has two ordinary unlocked doors. The main door opens to the gallery. The service door opens to a passage that bends by the pantry before reaching the archive and kitchen.

A walk from the library service door to the archive takes less than one minute at an ordinary pace. The bend prevents Arthur, near the kitchen side, from seeing the library doorway at 9:14.

The map is schematic, not to scale. The gallery is on the ground floor. The east stair leads to the upstairs linen room where Martha and Nora were together from 9:12 to 9:18.

No hidden mechanism: No secret door, altered clock or remote bell exists in this case. Mud and water in the passage cannot identify a unique visitor. The route establishes opportunity only.

